comfortable Circuit House and had been quite content to sit back, secure in the belief that Bomdila was too far removed from any immediate threat from the Chinese. The high command expected a linear sequence of events: first Se-la would have to fall, then Dirang, only after that would Bomdila come into the reckoning. On arrival at Bomdila, 4 Sikh LI had been taken away from 48 Brigade and given to 62 Brigade on Se-la. Gurbax was then left with 1 Sikh LI under Lieutenant Colonel M. S. Brar and 5 Guards commanded by Lieutenant Colonel Jai Singh. 1 Madras was then rushed in from Nagaland to reinforce the Brigade.

However, everything changed on 15 November when news filtered in from the Assam Rifles that the Chinese had overrun the small force at Poshing-la. By the evening of 16 November, the bulk of 5 Guards had moved to KM 9 on the road to Dirang, from where they dropped down to occupy Thembang which they reached by 2 p. m. One company had marched through the night and had arrived earlier in the morning. It was decided to locate the battalion's defences in an open patch just below the Thembang village. As the troops began to dig themselves in, their trenches were barely a foot deep when the Chinese were seen coming down from Poshing-la.

Jai Singh immediately sent a screening patrol out, but the Chinese barely paused in their stride and pushed the Guardsmen back into the partly constructed defences. Four 25-pounder guns had been deployed at KM 9 from where they opened fire on the Chinese as they began to form up for an attack. According to a local Sherdukpen, who witnessed the fighting, the effect of the artillery guns was devastating, killing among others a high-ranking Chinese officer on a grey pony. However, showing tremendous discipline, despite the high number of casualties, the Chinese continued to attack 5 Guards. Chinese mortars quickly deployed among the vegetation and began to pepper the Indian position. Second Lieutenant S. S. Choudhary tried to neutralize the Chinese mortars by climbing a tree with an LMG, but a sniper killed him almost immediately.

Despite the reports sent by the Assam Rifles of there being more than a thousand Chinese soldiers approaching Poshing-la, Gurbax and Jai Singh had estimated that at best the Chinese could have pushed 'a few hundred' men across the pass. As a result, 5 Guards was carrying limited ammunition, which by 4.30 p.m. was beginning to run out. With casualties mounting, Jai Singh asked Gurbax if he could withdraw. Permission was